

PDF EDITORS

Looking beyond proprietary: A Guide to Open Source PDF Editors

The ‘Portable Document Format’, known more popularly by its abbreviation ‘PDF’, is one of the most widely used platforms to exchange and preserve documents across the globe today. So far, this domain has been dominated by Adobe systems – a phenomenon which can be attributed to the fact that PDF was a proprietary format till the year 2008. Basically, the entire control over the format rested with Adobe Systems until then.

But seven years on, Adobe Acrobat and its freeware reader version Adobe Reader are still the last word on PDFs and are the premier software most users turn to, when they have to edit and read PDFs, respectively. With the introduction of Document Cloud (DC), Adobe now has a few additional features like sending forms and digital signatures, and also boasts of improved portability of documents between mobile and computers. And besides its commendable ability to convert scanned documents into editable PDFs efficiently, Acrobat also allows interlinking within the document, where you can let the users jump from one part of the document to another using links, a very good feature for referencing.

However, how useful are all these unique features for the lay user? Or, for that matter, are they even affordable, given that the software is available only to those who are ready to shell out the princely sum of Rs. 20,000? Adobe Reader might be available free of cost, but it allows limited editing. Not to